

Personification in ancient rhetorical discourse

Rhet. Her. 4.66 (trans. Caplan)

1. Conformatio est, cum aliqua, quae non adest, persona confingitur quasi adsit, aut cum res muta aut informis fit eloquens, et forma ei et oratio adtribuitur ad dignitatem adcommodata, aut actio quaedam, hoc pacto:

“Quodsi nunc haec urbs invictissima vocem mittat, non hoc pacto loquatur: ‘Ego illa plurimis tropeis ornata, triumphis ditata certissimis, clarissimis locupletata victoriis, nunc vestris seditionibus, o cives, vexor; quam dolis malitiosa Kartago, viribus probata Numantia, disciplinis erudita Corinthus labefactare non potuit, eam patimini nunc ab homunculis deterrumis proteri atque conculcari?’”

2. Item: “Quodsi nunc Lucius ille Brutus revivescat et hic ante pedes vestros adsit, is non hac utatur oratione: ‘Ego reges eieci, vos tyrannos introducitis; ego libertatem, quae non erat, peperit, vos partem servare non vultis; ego capitis mei periculo patriam liberavi, vos liberi sine periculo esse non curatis?’”

3. Haec conformatio licet in plures <res>, in mutas atque inanimas transferatur. Proficit plurimum in amplificationis partibus et commiseratione.

Personification consists in representing an absent person as present, or in making a mute thing or one lacking form articulate, and attributing to it a definite form and a language or a certain behaviour appropriate to its character, as follows:

“But if this invincible city would now give utterance to her voice, would she not speak as follows? ‘I, city of renown, who have been adorned with numerous trophies, enriched with unconditional triumphs, and made opulent by famous victories, am now vexed, O citizens, by your dissensions. Her whom Carthage with her wicked guile, Numantia with her tested strength, and Corinth with her polished culture, could not shake, do you now suffer to be trod upon and trampled underfoot by worthless weaklings?’”

Again: “But if that great Lucius Brutus should now come to life again and appear here before you, would he not use this language? ‘I banished kings; you bring in tyrants. I created liberty, which did not exist; what I created you do not wish to preserve. I, at peril of my life, freed the fatherland; you, even without peril, do not care to be free.’”

Personification may be applied to a variety of things, mute and inanimate. It is most useful in the divisions under Amplification and in Appeal to Pity.

Quint. Inst. 9.2.29–37 (trans. Butler)

... *Illa adhuc audaciora et maiorum, ut Cicero existimat, laterum, fictiones personarum, quae προσωποποιΐαι dicuntur: mire namque cum uariant orationem tum excitant. (30) His et aduersariorum cogitationes uelut secum loquentium protrahimus (qui tamen ita demum a fide non abhorrent si ea locutos finxerimus quae cogitasse eos non sit absurdum), et nostros cum aliis sermones et aliorum inter se credibiliter introducimus, et suadendo, obiurgando, querendo, laudando, miserando personas idoneas damus. (31) Quin deducere deos in hoc genere dicendi et inferos excitare concessum est. Vrbes etiam populique uocem accipiunt. Ac sunt quidam qui has demum προσωποποιΐας dicant in quibus et corpora et uerba fingimus: sermones hominum adsimulatos dicere διαλόγους malunt, quod Latinorum quidam dixerunt sermocinationem. (32) Ego iam recepto more utrumque eodem modo appellauit: nam certe sermo fingi non potest ut non personae sermo fingatur. Sed in iis quae natura non permittit hoc modo mollior fit figura: «etenim si mecum patria mea, quae mihi uita mea multo est carior, si cuncta Italia, si omnis res publica sic loquatur: Marce Tulli, quid agis?» Illud audacius genus: «quae tecum, Catilina, sic agit et quodam modo tacita loquitur: nullum iam aliquot annis facinus extitit nisi per te.» (33) Commode etiam aut nobis aliquas ante oculos esse rerum personarum uocum imagines fingimus, aut eadem aduersariis aut iudicibus non accidere miramur: qualia sunt «uidetur mihi» et «nonne uidetur tibi?» Sed magna quaedam uis eloquentiae desideratur. Falsa enim et incredibilia natura necesse est aut magis moueant, quia supra uera sunt, aut pro uanis accipiantur, quia uera non sunt. (34) Vt dicta autem quaedam, ita scripta quoque fingi solent, quod facit Asinius pro Liburnia: «mater mea, quae mihi cum carissima tum dulcissima fuit, quaeque mihi uixit bisque eodem die uitam dedit» et reliqua, deinde «exheres esto». Haec cum per se figura est, tum duplicatur quotiens, sicut in hac causa, ad imitationem alterius scripturae componitur. (35) Nam contra recitabatur testamentum: «P. Nouanius Gallio, cui ego omnia meritissimo uolo et debeo pro eius animi in me summa uoluntate», et adiectis deinceps aliis «heres esto»: incipit esse quodam modo παρωιδή, quod nomen ductum a canticis ad aliorum similitudinem modulatis abusiue etiam in uersificationis ac sermonum imitatione seruatur. (36) Sed formas quoque fingimus saepe, ut Famam Vergilius, ut Voluptatem ac Virtutem, quem ad modum a Xenophonte traditur, Prodicus, ut Mortem ac Vitam, quas contententes in satura tradit, Ennius. Est et incerta persona ficta oratio: «hic aliquis» et «dicat aliquis». (37) Est et iactus sine persona sermo: «hic Dolopum manus, hic saeuus tendebat Achilles». Quod fit mixtura figurarum, cum προσωποποιΐαι accedit illa quae est orationis per detractionem: detractum est enim quis diceret. Vertitur interim προσωποποιΐα in speciem narrandi. Vnde apud historicos reperiuntur obliquae adlocutiones, ut in Titi Liui primo statim: «urbes quoque ut cetera ex infimo nasci, deinde, quas sua uirtus ac di iuuent, magnas opes sibi magnumque nomen facere.»*

... A bolder form of figure, which in Cicero's opinion demands greater effort, is impersonation, or προσωποποιΐα. This is a device which lends wonderful variety and animation to oratory. (30) By this means we display the inner thoughts of our adversaries as though they were talking with themselves (but we shall only carry conviction if we represent them as uttering what they may reasonably be supposed to have had in their minds); or without sacrifice of credibility we may introduce conversations between ourselves and others, or of others among themselves, and put words of advice, reproach, complaint, praise or pity into the mouths of appropriate persons. (31) Nay, we are even allowed in this form of speech to bring down the gods from heaven and raise the dead, while cities also and peoples may find a voice. There are some authorities who restrict the term impersonation to cases where both persons and words are fictitious, and prefer

to call imaginary conversations between men by the Greek name of dialogue, which some translate by the Latin *sermocinatio*. (32) For my own part, I have included both under the same generally accepted term, since we cannot imagine a speech without we also imagine a person to utter it. But when we lend a voice to things to which nature has denied it, we may soften down the figure in the way illustrated by the following passage: “For if my country, which is far dearer to me than life itself, if all Italy, if the whole commonwealth were to address me thus, ‘Marcus Tullius, what dost honour?’” A bolder figure of the same kind may be illustrated by the following: “Your country, Catiline, pleads with you thus, and though she utters never a word, cries to you, ‘For not a few years past no crime has come to pass save through your doing!’” (33) It is also convenient at times to pretend that we have before our eyes the images of things, persons or utterances, or to marvel that the same is not the case with our adversaries or the judges; it is with this design that we use phrases such as “It seems to me,” or “Does it not seem to you?” But such devices make a great demand on our powers of eloquence. For with things which are false and incredible by nature there are but two alternatives: either they will move our hearers with exceptional force because they are beyond the truth, or they will be regarded as empty nothings because they are not the truth. (34) But we may introduce not only imaginary sayings, but imaginary writings as well, as is done by Asinius in his defence of Liburnia: “Let my mother, who was the object of my love and my delight, who lived for me and gave me life twice in one day (and so on) inherit nought of my property.” This is in itself a figure, and is doubly so whenever, as in the present case, it imitates a document produced by the opposing party. (35) For a will had been read out by the prosecution, in the following form: “Let Publius Novanius Gallio, to whom as my benefactor I will and owe all that is good, as a testimony to the great affection which he has borne me (then follow other details) be my heir.” In this case the figure borders on parody, a name drawn from songs sung in imitation of others, but employed by an abuse of language to designate imitation in verse or prose. (36) Again, we often personify the abstract, as Virgil does with Fame, or as Xenophon records that Prodicus did with Virtue and Pleasure, or as Ennius does when, in one of his satires, he represents Life and Death contending with one another. We may also introduce some imaginary person without identifying him, as we do in the phrases, “At this point some one will interpose,” or, “Some one will say.” (37) Or speech may be inserted without any mention of the speaker, as in the line: “Here the Colopian host / Camped, here the fierce Achilles pitched his tent.” This involves a mixture of figures, since to impersonation we add the figure known as ellipse, which in this case consists in the omission of any indication as to who is speaking. At times impersonation takes the form of narrative. Thus we find indirect speeches in the historians, as at the opening of Livy’s first book: “That cities, like other things, spring from the humblest origins, and that those who are helped by their own valour and the favour of heaven subsequently win great power and a great name for themselves.”